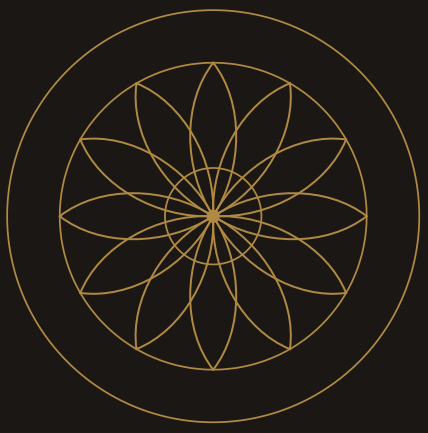


THE SACRED DIVIDE

THE FULL RECORD

Oriental Orthodoxy

Christianity family

HONOR THE FAITH · NAME THE MACHINERY

TEXT CHECKED 2026-10-03

Before you begin

This is the record of Oriental Orthodoxy in *The Sacred Divide*. It has 27 sections, the same 27 used for every tradition, so that any section can be set beside the same section for another. Every fact is sourced.

Before each section, a short note says what the section is built to show, so you know what you are looking at before you read the detail.

After each section, a note headed *Why this matters to you* points at the part of the section most likely to touch an ordinary reader: a member, a donor, a parent, a voter, someone thinking about leaving, or someone outside forming an opinion. It usually ends with a question. The questions are not traps. They are the ones a careful reader would ask anyway.

The hard questions in section 23 are set out one at a time: the question, why it is asked, and an example already documented in this record.

Where a note states a fact, the fact comes from this record's own tables and cited sources or, in a few places, from a well-known research finding named in the text. Corrections are logged, with their dates, in the last section, *What changed on this page*.

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How to read this

Every religion in The Sacred Divide is laid out the same way, in the same 27 sections, so that any section can be compared across religions. This file examines institutions, offices, money and power. It does not judge anyone's faith or the truth of any belief.

EVIDENCE GRADES

Each of the 30 techniques carries a grade for how it is established in this tradition.

- **CODIFIED** Written policy, published rule, contractual requirement, or a procedure the institution has confirmed in its own documents. The strongest grade and the hardest to deny.
- **DOCUMENTED** Established by court judgment, government inquiry, regulatory action, or financial filing. Not the institution's own words, but a body with subpoena power.
- **TAUGHT** Repeated leadership instruction from platform, publication, or curriculum, without a formal rule. Deniable as emphasis rather than policy.
- **CULTURAL** Community enforcement the institution neither mandates nor prevents. Real in effect, unattributable by design — the highest-deniability grade. A volume graded mostly Cultural has not been cleared of anything: it means the page names no document that makes the institution responsible. Cultural does not mean minor, and it is not a finding of absence.

- CONTESTED Occurs in some parts of the tradition and is actively opposed in others. Generalizing this grade across a whole tradition is a misuse of it.
- REFORMED Documented historically and materially changed since — policy withdrawn, practice ended, or independent oversight accepted. Recorded because omitting it would be dishonest.
- UNGRADED Present in the source material without a grade assigned yet. Read as an unverified pattern claim, not as a finding.

RECEIPTS

Bracketed labels such as [OFFICIAL POLICY] name the kind of source a claim rests on.

- **Official policy.** The institution's own written rule: handbook, canon, policy letter, catechism, trust deed, temple recommend question. The strongest evidence available, because it cannot be attributed to a rogue individual.
- **Court record.** Judgments, convictions, filings, and testimony given under oath. Adversarially tested, which is more than most religious claims about themselves have been.
- **Government inquiry.** Royal commissions, grand juries, parliamentary and state investigations with subpoena power. Where these exist they are usually the best record of what an institution did rather than said.
- **Regulatory action.** Findings and penalties from bodies like the SEC or consumer-protection regulators. Narrow in scope, unusually precise in what they establish.
- **Financial record.** Filings, audited statements, tax returns, disclosed compensation, property transactions. Frequently the only place an institution tells the truth about its priorities.

- **Leadership statement.** Recorded sermons, conference addresses, published letters. The institution in its own voice, to its own people, on the record.
- **Independent investigation.** Reports commissioned by the institution but conducted externally. Weaker than a court and far stronger than a press release — and notable when the institution publishes them in full.
- **Academic source.** Peer-reviewed history, sociology, and demography. Best for context, structure, and scale; weaker for specific institutional conduct.
- **Former member testimony.** Firsthand accounts from people who were inside. Indispensable and interested at once — graded as testimony, never presented as documentary proof.
- **Pattern observed.** A recurring configuration with no single document behind it. Labeled as an observation rather than a finding, and the weakest claim type in this codex.

METHOD

- Separation of targets. This codex analyzes institutional control patterns, never the worth of believers or the truth of beliefs. Theology is out of scope; behavior, money, and power are in scope.
- Pattern over anecdote. A tactic is attributed to a tradition's high-control expressions only where the mechanism recurs — one bad congregation proves nothing; the same architecture in a hundred proves the architecture.
- Evidence weighting. Every factual claim carries a bracketed source-type label and should carry a grade (A–D). Claims marked SOURCE NEEDED or PATTERN OBSERVED are analysis, not established fact, and must not be published as fact.
- Steelman rule. Every tactic section presents the institution's strongest defense before countering it. If the defense cannot be stated in a form its adherents would recognize, the counter is not yet earned.

- Asymmetry honesty. Similar tactic does not mean identical severity. A shunning policy that costs your entire family is not the same as a community that cools toward doubters, and the codex must never flatten that difference.
- The mirror rule. Any framework this powerful can itself be misused — to smear traditions, flatter one's own, or manufacture grievance. The self-audit and language guardrails apply to this project as much as to any institution it examines.

CITATIONS

A small raised number in the text links to the matching item in this religion's Sources, near the end. Every source was checked, and the date of the last check is shown at the top.

01 At a glance

BEFORE YOU READ

The whole page on one screen: how big Oriental Orthodoxy is, who sits at the top, how that person is chosen and whether anyone can remove them, where the money comes from, and what leaving costs. The disclosure scorecard underneath asks six yes-or-no questions any charity or public company would be expected to answer. Every later section expands one of these rows.

SIZE	Oriental Orthodoxy has about 60–70M adherents (72M in a 2020 estimate cited by reference works) [1].
WHO'S IN CHARGE	Each of the six churches has its own head. The Coptic Pope of Alexandria, Tawadros II, has led the Coptic Orthodox Church since 2012 [6].
CHOSEN BY	Electoral shortlist, then altar lot [6].
REMOVABLE BY	Death; no removal procedure.
MONEY IN ONE LINE	The money comes from church land, monasteries and diaspora giving, and in India two factions litigated for decades over about 1,100 churches [3].
LEAVING IN ONE LINE	In Egypt marriage and divorce run through the church and there is no civil marriage, so under current law a failed marriage can have no way out; a draft law before parliament would add provisions on divorce and annulment [4 26].

THE UNANSWERED QUESTION	When the state removes a patriarch, who in the church says no?
EVIDENCE	Seven of the 30 techniques are Documented and one is Codified. The grades are Cultural 16, Contested 3, Taught 3, Documented 7 and Codified 1.
FAMILY	Christianity — christianity, catholicism, eastern-orthodoxy, oriental-orthodoxy, anglicanism, protestant-evangelical, pentecostal-charismatic, plymouth-brethren
LAST CHECKED	2026-10-03

Disclosure scorecard

ACCOUNTS	PAY	SAFEGUARDING	EXTERNAL FIRST	REMOVAL	REPLY
PARTIAL	PARTIAL	PARTIAL	NO	NO	NO

Accounts: rated on the Coptic Orthodox Church's UK body, which files public accounts; most churches in this family publish none [24]

Pay: the UK filing discloses its highest earners in pay bands [24]

Safeguarding: declares a safeguarding policy to the regulator; its text is not published [24]

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

The glance table's answer to who chooses the top office is "Electoral shortlist, then altar lot", and to who can remove its holder, "Death; no removal procedure". Read that as though it described the board of a pension fund holding your savings. Would you accept the arrangement there? The scorecard finds no public evidence of allegations going to police first, a written removal procedure or on-the-record replies. Each "No" is something the institution could publish tomorrow. Ask yourself why it hasn't.

02 A day inside

BEFORE YOU READ

One ordinary day, told from inside. The person is a composite built from documented patterns, not a real individual. The point is to make the structure visible at human scale: phrases like "removal mechanism" or "giving record" are easy to read past, but a Tuesday organized around them is not.

- **name:** Mariam
- **when:** A Tuesday in the Fast of the Apostles
- **where:** Cairo, Shubra

1. She wakes before six and does not eat, as she has not eaten before the Liturgy since she was a girl. The fast is a kind of quiet she has always loved.

2. On the way to work she passes the church where her aunt was married, and remembers the police at the door after Palm Sunday. The guards are still there. Nobody remarks on them any more.

3. At lunch her friend Nevine says the church council that rules on marriages will not hear her case this year. Nevine's husband left for the Gulf eight years ago. She is not divorced, cannot remarry, and cannot become anything else without losing her family and her name.

4. In the afternoon Mariam's mother calls about the priest's visit on Friday and whether the flat is ready.

5. In the evening she goes to vespers (evening prayer). The hymns are in Coptic, which she half understands, and it doesn't matter. She stands where the women stand and feels, as always, that this is the oldest thing she will ever be part of.

6. Walking home she thinks about Nevine and the council that will not hear her, and realizes she cannot imagine anyone she could ask to change it — not a priest, not a judge, not a president. She says a prayer for Nevine, because that is the only door she can see.

Mariam is a composite drawn from documented patterns. No real person is depicted.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Did any moment in that day feel familiar: a cost nobody questions, a door nobody can see how to open? The section of this page that explains that moment is the one to read first. If nothing felt familiar, ask whether that's because it isn't your life, or because the patterns have become normal to you.

03 The forefront

BEFORE YOU READ

The page's thesis in one place. First, the single question the documented record could not answer. Then the widest gap between what the institution says and what the record shows, one cost of leaving set beside how it is officially denied, and the strongest objection to this whole page, answered rather than dismissed.

> You may keep a fast longer than most people in the world have ever fasted, sing a liturgy older than most nations, and belong to a church that has buried more of its martyrs than any page in this book can count. Nothing here makes light of that. This page is about what happens when a church survives by bargaining with states, and about who pays the price of the bargain inside it.

THE UNANSWERED QUESTION

When the state removes a patriarch, who in the church says no?

The strongest objection, answered

- *Attack:* "You are criticizing persecuted Christians."
- *Concede:* These churches are among the most persecuted institutions in this book. The bombings are recorded first [9] [10].
- *Answer:* Persecution does not make a divorce rule just [4] or a state-managed patriarchate legitimate [2]. The martyrs' standard, refusing rulers, applies to the patriarchate as well.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Try answering the unanswered question yourself: *When the state removes a patriarch, who in the church says no?* If you can't, who could, and would asking them be welcome? How an institution reacts to a fair question often tells you more than the answer does.

04 What healthy looks like here

BEFORE YOU READ

What genuinely works in Oriental Orthodoxy, stated first and separately from any critique. That is a standing rule of this book: no tradition is reduced to its worst documented moments. Anything criticized later is measured against the best of what is described here.

> Oriental Orthodoxy has about 60–70 million faithful [1] in six autocephalous (self-governing) churches. The Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church is by far the largest; estimates range from about 36 to 60 million [1]. The others are the Coptic Orthodox Church, the Armenian Apostolic Church, the Eritrean Orthodox Tewahedo Church (about 2 to 3 million) [1], the Syriac Orthodox Church and the Malankara Orthodox Syrian Church of India.
>
> They are among the oldest Christian churches, known for ancient liturgies (Coptic, Ge'ez, Classical Armenian, Syriac), long fasting calendars, monasticism, and survival as minorities.

- These churches have kept an extraordinary continuity of liturgy, language and learning under centuries of pressure.
- Their monasteries historically offered refuge and education.
- The Coptic Church runs welfare and schools where the state provides little.
- The Armenian Church gives the laity real power: two-thirds of the assembly that elects the Catholicos (the church's supreme patriarch) are lay delegates [15].
- Twenty-five Armenian bishops publicly backed their Catholicos against state pressure [13] [30]. Solidarity against the state is also a check.

Some of that standard is already on the record. The Coptic Orthodox Church's UK body files public accounts with the charity regulator, discloses its highest earners in pay bands and declares a safeguarding policy [24]. Abune Antonios, Eritrea's patriarch, refused to excommunicate members of a Sunday-school renewal movement and called for the

release of prisoners, and he was removed for it [2]. Each is a place where the institution met the standard this page applies, and each is recorded here as credit.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

A bias check before the critique. People tend to read criticism of their own group as an attack and criticism of other groups as simply true. Social psychologists call this in-group bias; it shows up even when the groups are assigned at random (Tajfel's "minimal group" experiments, 1971). If you belong here, did this section feel fair? If you don't, did anything in it surprise you? The surprise is a rough measure of what you had assumed.

05 History

BEFORE YOU READ

A dated timeline and a few moments where the direction changed. Dates matter because they show that most rules had a beginning. A rule that began in a particular year, for a particular reason, is a rule that can be examined, and sometimes retired.

These churches separated from Rome and Constantinople after the Council of Chalcedon (451), over the formulation of Christ's nature; the Oriental churches hold a "miaphysite" Christology (the teaching that

Christ has one nature, at once divine and human). Each developed under a different state: - The Coptic Church developed under Byzantine and then Islamic rule. - The Ethiopian Church was a Christian empire's state church until the 1974 revolution [5]. - The Armenian Church developed in the first state to adopt Christianity (traditionally 301). - The Syriac Church developed across the Middle East. - The Malankara Church developed in Kerala, with ancient roots and later Syriac ties.

Timeline

DATE	EVENT	READING
301 (traditional)	Armenia adopts Christianity as its state religion	Church and nation fuse from the start.
451	The Council of Chalcedon meets, and the Oriental churches separate	A theological dispute becomes permanent institutional independence.
7th c.	Islamic armies conquer Egypt and Syria	Churches become protected minorities, with taxes and limits.
1915–23	The Armenian Genocide and the genocide of Assyrian/Syriac and Greek Christians are carried out. The International Association of Genocide Scholars recognized all three (2007); scholarly estimates are about 1.5M Armenians and 250,000–500,000 Assyrians killed [16]	Communities, clergy and property are destroyed. ACADEMIC SOURCE
1959	The Ethiopian church gains its own patriarch	The largest church becomes autocephalous.

1975–79	The Derg (the military government that took power in the 1974 revolution) nationalizes rural land (1975) [5] and arrests the Patriarch (1976), who is executed in 1979 [5]	The state church becomes a state target in five years.
2006	The Eritrean Patriarch is notified of his removal and house arrest (Jan 2006) and is taken to an undisclosed location in May 2007 [2]	It is the plainest state capture of a patriarchate in this book.
2010	Egypt's Supreme Administrative Court orders the church to license remarriage; the Supreme Constitutional Court halts the order's enforcement [4]	The state leaves the church's control over marriage in place.
1 Jan 2011	A church bombing in Alexandria kills 23 [9]	—
2012	The Coptic Pope is chosen by altar lot [6]	—
2016	Egypt passes its church-construction law (Law 80) [8]	The state regulates where Christians may pray; local authorities, not the president, now approve church building [8].
9 Apr 2017	Palm Sunday bombings at Tanta and Alexandria kill about 45 [10]	—
3 Jul 2017	India's Supreme Court upholds the 1934 Malankara constitution [3]	A secular court decides who owns churches.
2018–21	The abbot of St Macarius Monastery is murdered, and a former monk is executed for it in 2021 [11]	Violence inside a monastery is prosecuted by the state.
Feb 2022	The Eritrean Patriarch dies after 15+ years' house arrest [2]	—
Jan–Feb 2023	A breakaway Oromia synod splits the Ethiopian church; about 30 people are killed, and the prime minister brokers a settlement [7]	Ethnic politics enters the synod, and the state settles it.

2025–26	Armenia arrests archbishops (Jun 2025); one is sentenced to two years (Oct 2025), a verdict overturned on appeal in June 2026 [12] [25]; the Catholicos and six bishops go on trial (Aug 2026) [13]	A state moves against its national church.

Moments in the room

YEAR	TITLE	WHAT HAPPENED	WHY IT MATTERS
451	Chalcedon	The churches separated.	The independence later became isolation.
1975–79	The Derg	The Derg nationalized the land and executed the Patriarch [5].	It shows how quickly a state church becomes a state target.
2006	Eritrea	A government removed a patriarch [2].	It is state capture in its plainest form.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Pick one rule that shapes your week and look for it on the timeline. If it has a start date, it was decided by people at a particular moment, for reasons of that moment. Were you taught it as timeless? What would it mean for you if it turned out to be younger than your grandparents' grandparents?

06 Branches & variants

BEFORE YOU READ

Oriental Orthodoxy is not one bloc. This section maps the main branches and variants, so that nothing documented about one community is read as true of all of them.

The six autocephalous churches are in communion with one another. There are also internal splits: between the Malankara Orthodox and the Jacobites (the Malankara faction loyal to the Syriac Orthodox patriarch) [3]; regional crises in Ethiopia [7]; and the Tigrayan church's formation of its own administration in May 2021 after the Tigray war [17].

CHURCH	WHERE	HOW ITS HEAD IS CHOSEN, AND WHO ELSE HAS A HAND
Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo	Ethiopia and diaspora; by far the largest [1]	An electoral college of church representatives elects the patriarch (806 electors in 2013) [28]. The prime minister brokered the 2023 settlement of an Oromia synod schism [7], and the Tigrayan church set up its own administration in 2021 [17].
Coptic Orthodox	Egypt and diaspora	A blindfolded boy draws one of three shortlisted names at the altar, as in 2012 [6].
Armenian Apostolic	Armenia and diaspora	The Catholicos is elected for life by an assembly that is about two-thirds lay [15]. He went on trial in 2026 [13].

Eritrean Orthodox Tewahedo	Eritrea; about 2 to 3 million [1]	The government backed the removal of its patriarch in 2006 [2], and a new patriarch was enthroned in 2025 [18].
Syriac Orthodox	Syria, Iraq, Lebanon, Turkey, India and diaspora	A patriarch governs with a synod; in India, the Jacobite faction answers to him [3].
Malankara Orthodox Syrian	Kerala, India	It is governed by a 1934 constitution, which the Supreme Court upheld in 2017 [3].

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

If you know one community of Oriental Orthodoxy, you know one community. Most bad generalizations about a religion, and most unfair defenses of it, come from treating one branch as the whole. Which branch is the one you picture when you hear the name? Is that picture yours, or one you were given by news coverage or by the community itself?

07 Structure

BEFORE YOU READ

The organizational chart: how many people and institutions there are, where authority sits, who holds the top office, and who holds what beneath it. The question to keep in mind is simple: if the person at the top got something badly wrong, what written procedure exists to correct or remove them?

Size and shape

- **adherents:** Oriental Orthodoxy has about 60–70M adherents (72M in a 2020 estimate cited by reference works) [1].
- **regions:** The churches are concentrated in Ethiopia, Egypt, Armenia, Eritrea, Syria, Iraq, Lebanon and India (Kerala), and they have large diasporas.
- **branches:** The six autocephalous churches are in communion, and there are internal splits (between the Malankara Orthodox and Jacobite factions [3]; Ethiopian regional crises [7]; the Tigrayan church's formation of its own administration in May 2021 after the Tigray war [17]).
- **trend:** The churches are growing in Ethiopia; in the Middle East they are declining, and members are emigrating.
- **participation:** Ritual participation (fasting, feasts) is very high in Ethiopia and Egypt, where church identity is ethnic identity.

Authority

- Each church has its own patriarch or catholicos and holy synod.
- Selection differs by church:
- The Coptic Pope is chosen by lot: a blindfolded boy draws one of three shortlisted names at the altar (Pope Tawadros II, 4 Nov 2012) [6].

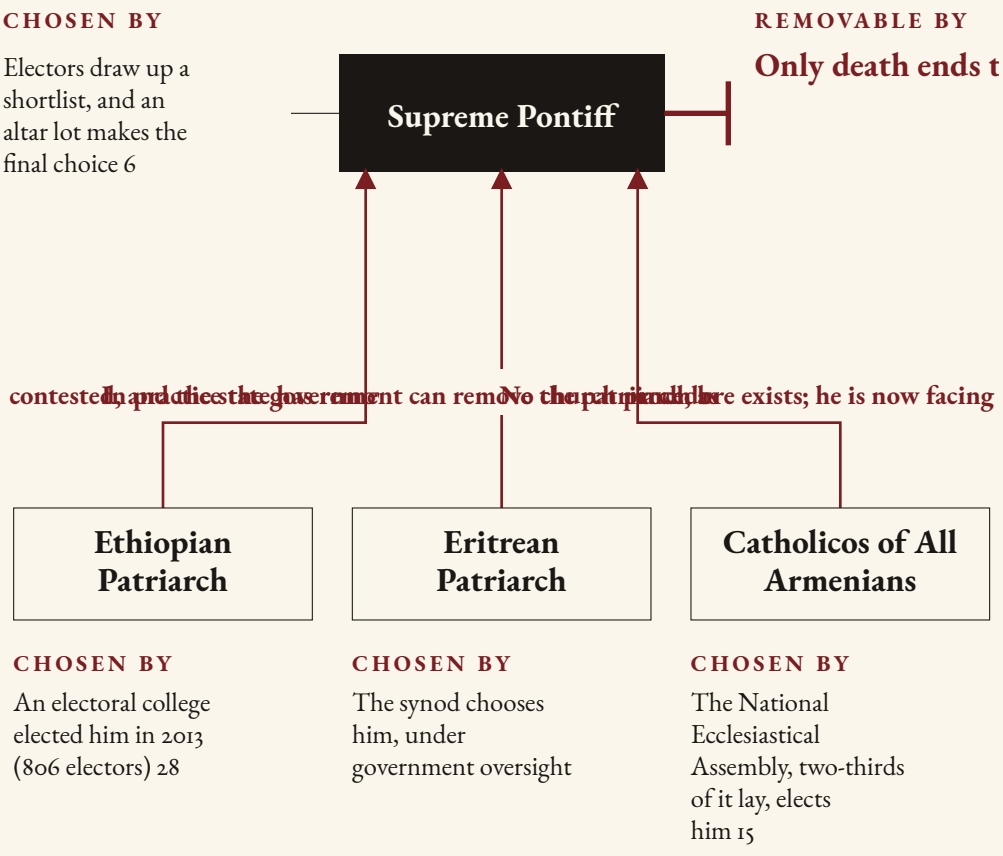
- The Armenian Catholicos is elected for life by a National Ecclesiastical Assembly: about two-thirds lay delegates and one-third clergy, elected by dioceses worldwide (Karekin II was elected in 1999 by about 450 delegates) [15].
- States reach into leadership:
- Eritrea's government backed the removal of its Patriarch (2006), who died under house arrest in 2022 [2]
- Ethiopia's prime minister brokered the 2023 settlement of a synod schism [7]
- Armenia's government has brought criminal cases against senior clergy and against the Catholicos himself (2025–26) [12] [13]

The top of the chain

> Six thrones, one question: which of them answers to a government?

In at least two of these churches the removal column's real answer is "the government", and in a third the government is trying.

WHERE THE ARROWS END



Each arrow points to whoever can remove the office below it. From the table that follows.

OFFICE	WHO SITS IN IT NOW	CHOSEN BY	REMOVABLE BY
Coptic Pope of Alexandria	Tawadros II, since 2012 [6]	Electors draw up a shortlist, and an altar lot makes the final choice [6]	Only death ends the office; there is no removal procedure
Ethiopian Patriarch	Abune Mathias (Abune, "our father", is the title of a patriarch or bishop) [7]	An electoral college elected him in 2013 (806 electors) [28]	The Synod can remove him, though this is contested, and the state has removed and executed a patriarch before [5]
Eritrean Patriarch	Abune Basilios, since 2025 [18]	The synod chooses him, under government oversight	In practice the government can remove the patriarch, as it did in 2006 [2]
Catholicos of All Armenians	Karekin II, since 1999 [13] [15]	The National Ecclesiastical Assembly, two-thirds of it lay, elects him [15]	No church procedure exists; he is now facing criminal trial [13]

> **THE TELL**
>
> In at least two of these churches the removal column's real answer is "the government", and in a third the government is trying.

Who holds what

ENTITY	TYPE	HOLDER	HOLDS	SECTOR	RECEIPT
Coptic Papacy	Patriarchate	Pope Tawadros II, since 2012 [6]	Doctrine, personal status (family law: marriage, divorce and remarriage), clergy	Coptic family law [4]	OFFICIAL POLICY

Ethiopian Patriarchate and Holy Synod	Patriarchate	Abune Mathias [7]	Church administration	The largest Oriental church	OFFICIAL POLICY
Eritrean Patriarchate	State-managed patriarchate	Abune Basilios, enthroned 26 Jan 2025 [18]	Under government oversight [2]	Every Eritrean parish	GOVERNMENT REPORT
Catholicos of All Armenians	Catholicosate	Karekin II — on trial, 2026 [13]	The national church	Church–state relations	COURT RECORD
Malankara factions	Rival administrations	Two synods	Churches under the 2017 ruling [3]	Your parish's ownership	COURT RECORD

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

These are the oldest churches in Christianity, and governments have repeatedly reached into them. Eritrea removed a patriarch. An Ethiopian prime minister brokered a synod settlement. Armenia has charged its Catholicos with obstructing a court order. If you belong to one of these churches, the page asks a hard question: when your church's leadership changes, who actually made the decision?

08 Law & state here

BEFORE YOU READ

What states actually do. That includes how they fund, protect, regulate or enforce the tradition, and which outside body, if any, can compel an answer from it. For most readers, this is where the institution meets their own passport.

COUNTRY	WHAT THE LAW DOES	THE ACCOUNTABILITY QUESTION
Egypt	Personal-status law is religious: the Coptic Church controls divorce and remarriage for Copts, and in 2010 the Supreme Constitutional Court halted an order that would have overridden it [4]; a 2016 law (Law 80) regulates building and repairing churches [8]	Under current law a Copt in a failed marriage has no civil route out [4]. In 2026 the government sent parliament a unified personal-status law for Christians, with new provisions on divorce and annulment; it had not passed as of September 2026 [26]
Eritrea	Only state-registered faiths may practice; the state removed the Orthodox patriarch in 2006 [2]	He died in 2022 after more than 15 years under house arrest [2]
Ethiopia	The Derg nationalized rural land in 1975, including the church's [5]	The state settled the 2023 synod schism [7]

Armenia	Criminal cases against senior clergy, 2025–26 [12]; the Catholicos and six bishops are charged with obstructing enforcement of a court order concerning a bishop he had removed (Article 507) [13]	Twenty-five bishops publicly backed the Catholicos [13] [30]
India	Secular courts decide church property: the Supreme Court gave the Malankara Orthodox faction the right to administer about 1,100 churches (2017) [3]	In 2024 Kerala's government told the courts it was unable to implement the ruling [3]; in 2026 it proposed mediation by the Chief Minister over six churches [27]

Who can compel an answer

Egyptian courts can compel an answer on personal status, and in 2010 the Supreme Constitutional Court halted an order against the church [4]. Indian courts can on property [3], and Armenian criminal courts have brought cases against clergy [12] [13]. In Eritrea no domestic body can. International bodies such as USCIRF (the US Commission on International Religious Freedom) and the UN report without power to compel [2].

Indian courts can on property, and Armenian criminal courts have brought cases against clergy.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

In Egypt, a Copt's marriage and divorce go through the church, because the state offers no civil marriage. In 2010 the Supreme Constitutional Court halted an order that would have overridden that arrangement. So, under current law, a Coptic woman in a failed marriage has no civil route out, though a draft law before parliament would add provisions on divorce and annulment. If you are Egyptian, did you know that the courts, not only the church, have been part of this? If you live abroad, would you accept that arrangement where you live now?

09 Money

BEFORE YOU READ

Where the money comes from, how each flow is justified, how it can be used to control, and who benefits. Read it the way you would read any organization you give to: what is disclosed, what is not, and who decides.

Where it comes from

- The money comes from church property, monasteries, land and diaspora parish giving.
- In Ethiopia the church lost all its land when the Derg nationalized rural land in March 1975. Estimates of prior church holdings range from 10 to 20% of cultivated land [5].
- The 2023 Ethiopian settlement allocated funding and resources to churches in Oromia [7], so money is part of how schisms are settled.
- In India, the Malankara Orthodox and Jacobite factions litigated for decades. In 2017 the Supreme Court gave the Orthodox faction the right to administer about 1,100 churches [3].

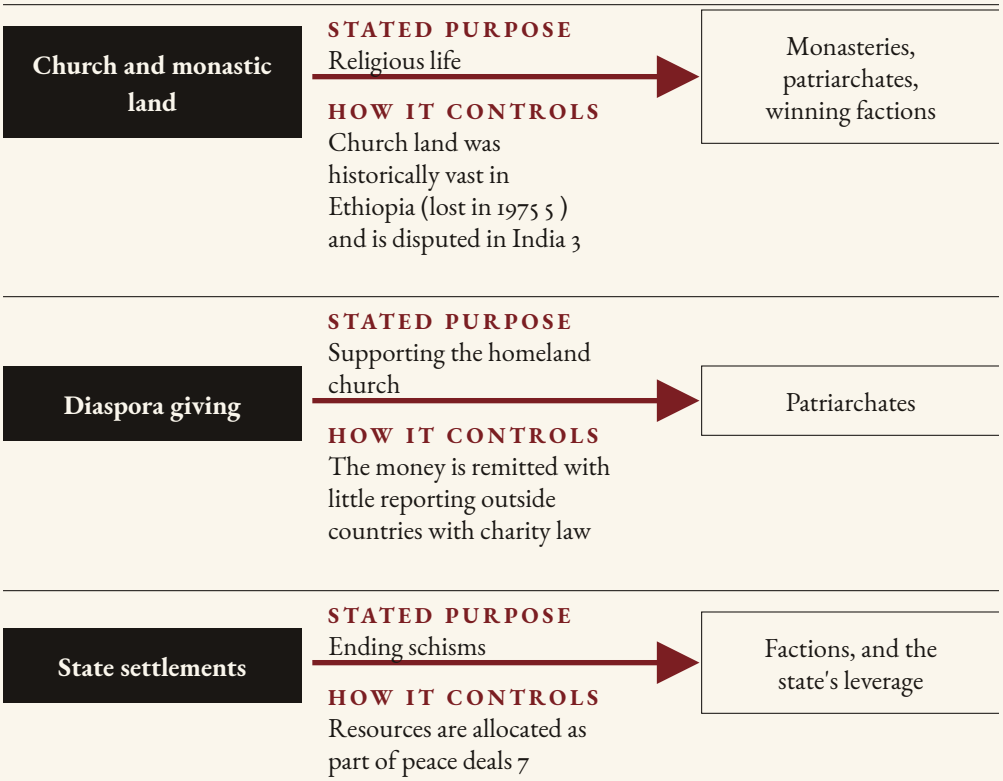
- Financial disclosure is generally minimal and jurisdiction-dependent. Diaspora parishes registered as charities in the UK file public accounts; in the US, churches are generally exempt from public filing [29].

Follow the money

FLOW	STATED PURPOSE	HOW IT CONTROLS	WHO BENEFITS
Sacramental and ritual fees	Services	Local clergy mediate access to the rites	Parishes, clergy
Church and monastic land	Religious life	Church land was historically vast in Ethiopia (lost in 1975 [5]) and is disputed in India [3]	Monasteries, patriarchates, winning factions
Diaspora giving	Supporting the homeland church	The money is remitted with little reporting outside countries with charity law	Patriarchates
State settlements	Ending schisms	Resources are allocated as part of peace deals [7]	Factions, and the state's leverage

WHERE THE MONEY GOES, AND WHAT IT HOLDS



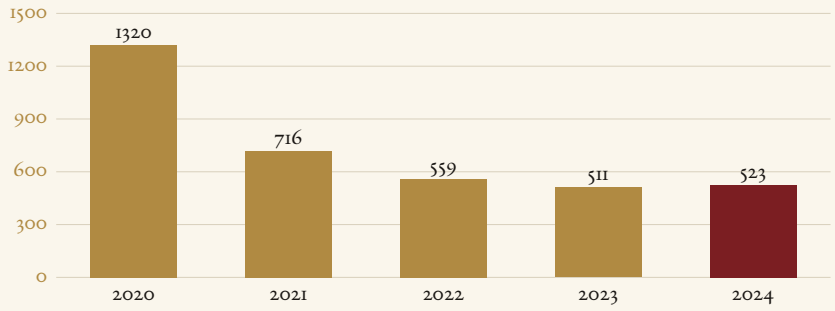


Not to scale. The table gives one figure, the German church tax of €6.75bn in 2025; the other flows are shown without amounts.

Money in numbers

Most of these churches publish no accounts. In the UK, diaspora bodies registered as charities must.

THE COPTIC ORTHODOX CHURCH CENTRE (UK): INCOME



£ thousand, years to 31 December — This is one UK Coptic charity, at Stevenage; parishes and the London diocese register separately. [19]

- **Coptic Orthodox Church Centre, 2024:** £446,130 of its £523,050 income came from donations and legacies, and it spent £645,920 [19].
- **Ethiopia:** the church's land, estimated at 10–20% of cultivated land before 1975, was nationalized by the Derg [5].
- **India:** the 2017 ruling on about 1,100 churches is, in effect, a ruling on property [3].
- **Ethiopia, 2023:** the settlement of the synod schism included funding and resources for churches in Oromia [7].

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Much of the money here is land and property: church estates, monasteries and diaspora parishes. In India, two factions of the Malankara church have fought for decades over about 1,100 churches, and a 2017 Supreme Court ruling on them has still not been fully implemented. Diaspora parishes registered as charities in the UK file public accounts; in the US, churches are generally exempt from public filing. Most of the rest disclose very little. If you give to a diaspora parish, ask whether any of it is sent home, and who accounts for it there.

10 Genealogy

BEFORE YOU READ

Rules with a history. Each card asks the same three questions: what was this rule originally for, has that reason expired, and who benefits from the rule continuing anyway?

1. **Church control of marriage and divorce (Egypt)** - *Origin:* Personal-status systems delegated family law to each religious community; Egypt's derives from the Ottoman millet system [31]. ACADEMIC SOURCE - *Then:* The system gave each community autonomy, and protection from majority family law. - *Expired?* With no civil-marriage alternative, the state's highest constitutional court halted an order that would have made the church license remarriage [4]. Autonomy becomes control over members with no exit. - *Benefits now:* The clerical hierarchy benefits.

2. **The patriarch as the state's interlocutor** - *Origin:* The community head answers to the ruler for the community. ACADEMIC SOURCE - *Then:* The arrangement secured the community's survival. - *Expired?* It lets states manage millions through one office. Eritrea removed its patriarch for refusing to excommunicate a youth movement and for demanding prisoners' release [2]. Ethiopia's prime minister settled a schism [7]. Armenia has charged its Catholicos with obstructing enforcement of a court order [13]. - *Benefits now:* States benefit, and so does whichever faction the state favors.

3. **Purity rules** - *Origin:* The rules come from Levitical purity traditions preserved in early canons (church laws) [14]. - *Then:* They kept ritual order. - *Expired?* Applied to women's bodies, they restrict half the church's access to its sacraments. - *Benefits now:* No one identifiable benefits. The custom is enforced by clergy.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

The expired-reason test works on any rule. Take one you follow or enforce, name what it was originally for, and ask whether that reason still exists. If it doesn't, and the rule survives anyway, the section's last question is the one that matters to you: who benefits from it continuing?

11 Reach

BEFORE YOU READ

How far the institution's authority extends into three private areas: what members may read and hear, how children are raised and schooled, and decisions about their own bodies.

Information

- Clerical authority over teaching is strong; lay theological critique is rare. **PATTERN OBSERVED**
- Under state control (Eritrea [2]; historically the Derg [5]), church communication is itself controlled.

Children

- Long fasting seasons are practiced from childhood.
- Church schools and Sunday schools are primary socialization. The Eritrean patriarch's refusal to excommunicate members of a Sunday-school renewal movement was among the charges used to remove him [2].

Bodies

- The priesthood and the episcopate (the order of bishops) are all male, and women are barred from the altar area. **OFFICIAL POLICY**
- In Ethiopian Orthodox practice, menstruating women do not enter the church for seven days, and after childbirth women stay away for 40

days (boy) or 80 days (girl) [14].

- In Egypt, church-controlled divorce falls hardest on spouses trapped in failed or abusive marriages [4].

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

If you are a parent, this is the section about your children: what they may read, what they are taught about their bodies, and who else has a say in their schooling. Ask what your child would need to do at sixteen to hear the strongest case against what they were taught. Would they be allowed? Would they know it existed?

Long fasting seasons are practiced from childhood.



12

The 30 techniques

How the thirty techniques are established here

1	7	3	16	3
CODIFIED	DOCUMENTED	TAUGHT	CULTURAL	CONTESTED

STAGE 1 Idealize	1 Love Bombing CULTURAL	2 Weaponized Generosity CONTESTED		
STAGE 2 Hook	3 Future Faking TAUGHT	4 Hoovering CULTURAL		
STAGE 3 Devalue	5 Devaluation TAUGHT	6 Gaslighting CULTURAL	7 Double Bind CODIFIED	
STAGE 4 Confuse	8 Intermittent Reinforcement CULTURAL	9 Moving the Goalposts DOCUMENTED	10 Strategic Ambiguity CULTURAL	11 Projection CULTURAL
	12 DARVO CONTESTED	13 Normalization / Desensitization CULTURAL		
STAGE 5 Isolate	14 Isolation CULTURAL	15 Triangulation CULTURAL		

STAGE 6 Extract	16 Flying Monkeys CULTURAL	17 Smear Campaign DOCUMENTED	18 Silent Treatment / Stonewalling DOCUMENTED	19 Manufactured Consent CULTURAL
	20 Trauma Bonding CULTURAL	21 Learned Helplessness DOCUMENTED	22 Benevolent Control TAUGHT	23 Infantilization CULTURAL
	24 Identity Erosion CULTURAL	25 Spiritual Bypassing CULTURAL	26 Financial Control CONTESTED	
STAGE 7 Discard	27 Manufactured Crisis CULTURAL	28 Discard DOCUMENTED		
STAGE 8 Replace	29 Replacement DOCUMENTED	30 Plausible Deniability DOCUMENTED		

Thirty named techniques from domestic-abuse and social-psychology research, applied to institutions, in the eight stages of the cycle.

BEFORE YOU READ

A fixed checklist of thirty influence and control patterns from research on coercive control and social psychology, applied here to institutions rather than to individual people. Every entry carries an evidence grade. The grade matters more than the name of the technique: Codified or Documented means there is a paper trail; Contested means the claim is disputed.

Thirty named techniques from domestic-abuse and social-psychology research, applied to institutions, in the eight stages of the cycle. Each carries an evidence grade for this tradition.

Stage 1 · Idealize

You arrive with a need and are met with more warmth than you have had in years.

You belong to an ancient, suffering, beautiful church that is also your nation.

What it asks of you: Is the belonging to the people or to the office?

1 · Love Bombing

Overwhelming affection on arrival to create emotional dependency before terms are revealed.

How it shows here

- Belonging comes through the ethnic community rather than through recruitment.

The strongest defense. We are a people.

The counter. The belonging is never offered as a choice.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> CULTURAL Belonging through the ethnic community is how membership works in practice; it is not a recruitment rule.

2 · Weaponized Generosity

Giving help that installs unspoken obligation.

How it shows here

- The church provides welfare where the state is absent.

The strongest defense. Charity.

The counter. Help that is the only help creates debt.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> CONTESTED Church welfare where the state is absent is real; whether it creates obligation is disputed.

Stage 2 · Hook

You are given a future that cannot be verified, and a rope for whenever you drift toward the door.

Salvation comes through sacraments only this church administers.

What it asks of you: Is access to God routed through one institution?

3 · Future Faking

Promising a future that keeps you invested but never has to arrive.

How it shows here

- Salvation is promised through the church's sacraments.

The strongest defense. Orthodox faith.

The counter. Access is controlled by the office.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> TAUGHT Salvation through the sacraments is the church's teaching.

4 · Hoovering

Pulling someone back after they've started to leave, through guilt, love, or fear.

How it shows here

- Family and priests recall the lapsed at feasts and fasts.

The strongest defense. Pastoral care.

The counter. Care that costs identity if refused is pressure.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> CULTURAL Recalling the lapsed at feasts and fasts is family and parish custom.

Stage 3 · Devalue

You are taught that you are broken, that your perception is unreliable, and that both exits from the trap lead back inside.

Fasting failures and impurity are treated as spiritual inadequacy [14].

What it asks of you: Who set the standard?

5 · Devaluation

Reducing your sense of worth so you become dependent on the institution for identity.

How it shows here

- Failing to fast, and ritual impurity, are treated as unworthiness [14].

The strongest defense. Discipline.

The counter. Who decides what the body owes?

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> TAUGHT Unworthiness through missed fasts and impurity is taught in the church's practice [14].

6 · Gaslighting

Making you doubt your own experience so you trust the institution's interpretation instead.

How it shows here

- Complaints about clergy are framed as weak faith.

The strongest defense. Respect the fathers.

The counter. Respect is not an answer.

EVIDENCE GRADE

CULTURAL Framing complaints as weak faith is a reported pattern, not a rule.

7 · Double Bind

A trap where both options lead to compliance. No exit serves you.

How it shows here

- Marriage is holy, and a failed one cannot end [4].

The strongest defense. A sacrament is permanent.

The counter. The permanence falls on the spouse who cannot leave, not on the church that set the rule.

EVIDENCE GRADE

CODIFIED The Coptic rule that a marriage cannot end except on narrow grounds is written church law [4].

Stage 4 · Confuse

The rewards become unpredictable, the standard keeps moving, the answers stop meaning anything, and the accusation gets turned around.

Criticism is framed as helping the persecutors of Christians [9] [10].

What it asks of you: Persecution is real. Does it end the question?

8 · Intermittent Reinforcement

Unpredictable reward that creates addictive emotional dependency.

How it shows here

- Clergy show favor to the observant.

The strongest defense. Rewarding devotion.

The counter. Favor rationed by conformity trains conformity.

EVIDENCE GRADE

CULTURAL Favour toward the observant is reported practice.

9 · Moving the Goalposts

The standard of success keeps shifting so you can never arrive.

How it shows here

- Divorce grounds were narrowed to adultery [4].

The strongest defense. Restoring canon.

The counter. Narrowing the grounds left spouses in failed marriages with no way out.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> DOCUMENTED The narrowing of divorce grounds is on the court and press record [4].

10 · Strategic Ambiguity

Language that sounds profound but means nothing specific — functioning as a shutdown to real questions.

How it shows here

- Purity rules are called "custom" and enforced like doctrine [14].

The strongest defense. Tradition.

The counter. The rules are enforced like doctrine and defended as custom.

EVIDENCE GRADE

CULTURAL The purity rules are enforced as custom; no written canon is cited on this page [14].

11 · Projection

Accusing the outside world of the exact thing the institution practices.

How it shows here

- Critics are cast as agents of hostile outsiders.

The strongest defense. We are besieged.

The counter. The siege is real; the accusation is misplaced.

EVIDENCE GRADE

CULTURAL Casting critics as agents of outsiders is a pattern in church messaging.

12 · DARVO

Deny the wrongdoing. Attack the person who raised it. Reverse victim and offender.

How it shows here

- Spouses seeking divorce are framed as destroying families.

The strongest defense. Protecting marriage.

The counter. Protecting the marriage can mean leaving the harmed spouse inside it.

EVIDENCE GRADE

CONTESTED Whether spouses seeking divorce are framed this way by the church, or by families, is disputed.

13 · Normalization / Desensitization

Practices that would seem extreme to an outsider feel normal to insiders because they were installed before critical evaluation developed.

How it shows here

- Long fasts and purity restrictions begin in childhood [14].

The strongest defense. Our ancient way.

The counter. Ancient is not consent.

EVIDENCE GRADE

CULTURAL Childhood fasting and purity rules are community practice [14].

Stage 5 · Isolate

Your world narrows until every voice you hear is inside the system, and everything you came for now runs through a middleman.

Community identity is church identity, especially in the diaspora.

What it asks of you: Where can you be Coptic and outside the church?

14 · Isolation

Shrinking your world until the only voices you hear are inside the system.

How it shows here

- Minority identity makes the church the whole world.

The strongest defense. Survival.

The counter. Survival can become a wall.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> CULTURAL Minority identity making the church the whole world is a social pattern, not a rule.

15 · Triangulation

Inserting intermediaries between you and the thing you came for, so the institution is always in the middle.

How it shows here

- Family, priest and community align on marriage and fasting.

The strongest defense. Everyone agrees.

The counter. Everyone in the triangle is inside.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> CULTURAL Family, priest and community aligning is reported practice.

Stage 6 · Extract

Now the harvest: your labor, your money, your identity, your silence, your children's schooling, your capacity to trust yourself.

The church takes fees, labor and loyalty, and it holds the permission to marry [4].

What it asks of you: Who holds the keys to your second marriage?

16 · Flying Monkeys

The community enforces the institution's norms without being asked — mobilized by culture, not memos.

How it shows here

- Relatives enforce return and conformity.

The strongest defense. Family duty.

The counter. The office never has to speak.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> CULTURAL Relatives enforcing conformity is reported practice.

17 · Smear Campaign

Rewriting your character after departure to protect the institution from the implications of your leaving.

How it shows here

- Dissenting movements are labeled divisive; the Eritrean Sunday-school movement, for example, was targeted for excommunication [2].

The strongest defense. Protecting unity.

The counter. It is a unity that requires excommunicating children's teachers.

EVIDENCE GRADE

DOCUMENTED USCIRF records the action against the Eritrean Sunday-school movement [2].

18 · Silent Treatment / Stonewalling

Refusing to engage with legitimate questions in order to maintain control.

How it shows here

- The church refused to comply with a remarriage order [4].

The strongest defense. God's law above courts.

The counter. And then the top court halted the order [4].

EVIDENCE GRADE

DOCUMENTED The church's refusal and the later court halt are on the record [4].

19 · Manufactured Consent

Creating the appearance of choice when the conditions of choice were shaped before you could evaluate them.

How it shows here

- Infant baptism confers a lifelong identity.

The strongest defense. Grace.

The counter. The identity comes before any choice.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> CULTURAL Infant baptism conferring identity is ordinary practice.

20 · Trauma Bonding

The wound and the bandage come from the same hand.

How it shows here

- Shared martyrdom memory [9] [10] binds members to the hierarchy.

The strongest defense. We suffered together.

The counter. Members suffered together with each other, not only with the office.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> CULTURAL Shared memory of martyrdom [9] [10] binding members is a pattern described by members.

21 · Learned Helplessness

Teaching you that your own judgment is unreliable until you stop trusting it entirely.

How it shows here

- In Egypt there is no civil route out of church marriage rules [4].

The strongest defense. It is our law.

The counter. A law with no exit teaches people to stop asking.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> DOCUMENTED Egyptian law gives no civil route out of church marriage rules [4].

22 · Benevolent Control

Control wrapped in the language of care, so that resisting the control feels like rejecting the love.

How it shows here

- Divorce restrictions are framed as protecting families [4].

The strongest defense. For the family.

The counter. It is protection that cannot be refused.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> TAUGHT The church teaches the restrictions as protection for families [4].

23 · Infantilization

Positioning the adult believer as permanently childlike and dependent on institutional authority.

How it shows here

- Laity defer to clergy on family decisions.

The strongest defense. Humility.

The counter. Adults decide their own marriages.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> CULTURAL Lay deference to clergy on family matters is reported practice.

24 · Identity Erosion

Gradually replacing your identity with a role the institution provides, until you can't separate who you are from where you belong.

How it shows here

- Church, ethnicity and self are fused.

The strongest defense. We are one people.

The counter. Then leaving means ceasing to exist.

EVIDENCE GRADE

CULTURAL The fusion of church, ethnicity and self is a social pattern.

25 · Spiritual Bypassing

Using spiritual language to avoid engaging with real pain, real questions, and real accountability.

How it shows here

- Suffering in marriage is called "a cross to bear".

The strongest defense. Patience.

The counter. Patience is asked only of the harmed.

EVIDENCE GRADE

CULTURAL Calling suffering in marriage a cross to bear is reported pastoral practice.

26 · Financial Control

Extracting money through spiritual obligation while offering no transparency about where it goes.

How it shows here

- The church takes fees, and schisms have been settled with funding [7]; no figures for diaspora remittances are recorded on this page.

The strongest defense. Supporting the church.

The counter. Publish what is sent and settled.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
> CONTESTED Fees and settlements are recorded [7], but no figures for remittances are, so the grade is disputed.

Stage 7 · Discard

You become expensive — too many questions, too much independence — and the urgency ramps up until you are removed.

Members face excommunication and refused remarriage [4].

What it asks of you: Can you leave without losing both church and people?

27 · Manufactured Crisis

Creating urgency to suppress critical thinking and generate loyalty.

How it shows here

- Outside threats are cited to end internal debate.

The strongest defense. The danger is real.

The counter. The threats are real, and they are used.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> CULTURAL Citing outside threats to end debate is a pattern in church messaging.

28 · Discard

Removing members who become too costly — too many questions, too much independence, too visible a contradiction.

How it shows here

- Members face excommunication, and priests who obey courts are threatened with defrocking [4].

The strongest defense. Canonical discipline.

The counter. The discipline is aimed at obedience to a court.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> DOCUMENTED Press reports record the excommunications and the threats to priests [4].

Stage 8 · Replace

Your seat is filled before the door shuts, and nobody is responsible for any of it because the authority was attributed to God.

The liturgy continues.

What it asks of you: Is being unchanged for a thousand years also a form of power?

29 · Replacement

Your seat is filled before the door closes behind you.

How it shows here

- Rival synods and bishops are appointed in schisms [7].

The strongest defense. Order restored.

The counter. Order is restored by replacing people.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> DOCUMENTED Rival synods and appointed bishops are on the press record [7].

30 · Plausible Deniability

The institution is never responsible, because the authority is attributed to God — who isn't available for cross-examination.

How it shows here

- Patriarchates cite the state; states cite the church [2] [13].

The strongest defense. It is their internal matter.

The counter. Both hold the pen.

> EVIDENCE GRADE
>
> **DOCUMENTED** USCIRF and press reports record church and state each citing the other [2] [13].

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Count grades, not names. A long list of Contested entries says something very different from a short list of Codified ones. A bias to watch for in yourself: people rate the same pressure as "normal" when their own group applies it and as "manipulation" when another group does. Before you judge an entry, try imagining it applied by a group you distrust. Does it look different?

13

The loops

BEFORE YOU READ

How the techniques connect into cycles. A single practice can look harmless on its own. The loops show how one step feeds the next, so that, for example, a newcomer's welcome turns into an obligation.

> The seven loops below show how the practices connect, so that each step makes the next one easier and the last step feeds the first. The loops are analysis built from findings recorded elsewhere on this page PATTERN OBSERVED; each step names the section or technique where its fact is recorded. The techniques are set out in the table in section 12.

1 · Money



I

Sacramental access funds the clergy who administer it.

How it runs.

1. Salvation is taught as coming through sacraments that only this church administers (section 12, stage Hook; technique 3).
2. Local clergy mediate access to the rites, and sacramental and ritual fees are paid for services (section 9, Follow the money).

3. The fees go to parishes and clergy, and diaspora giving is remitted to the patriarchates with little reporting outside countries with charity law (section 9).
4. Most of these churches publish no accounts; the Coptic Orthodox Church's UK body, which files with the charity regulator, is the exception the scorecard rates (sections 1 and 9).
5. The clergy sustained this way administer the same sacraments on the same terms, and the fees and giving continue (technique 26).

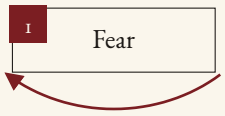
Techniques that feed it. 3 · Future faking, 26 · Financial control, 8 · Intermittent reinforcement.

Why it closes. The office that controls access to the sacraments also receives the fees and the giving that sustain it, and outside countries with charity law no one publishes what is received or sent. A member cannot reach the rites without the clergy, and cannot see the accounts without their permission.

Where it could be broken, and by whom. It weakens wherever accounts are published. Diaspora bodies registered as charities in the UK file accounts and disclose pay bands (sections 1 and 9), and section 12 states the remedy for technique 26: publish what is sent and settled. A donor can ask a diaspora parish for its accounts before giving. This paragraph is analysis, not a documented finding.

An example from this page. In 2024 the Coptic Orthodox Church Centre in the UK took £446,130 of its £523,050 income from donations and legacies (section 9). Most churches in this family publish no comparable figure.

2 · Fear



2

Salvation is taught to come through the church's sacraments, and members face excommunication and, for priests who obey a court, the threat of defrocking.

How it runs.

1. Salvation is promised through the church's sacraments, and access to them is controlled by the office (technique 3).
2. Failing to fast, and ritual impurity, are treated as unworthiness, so a member always has something to answer for (technique 5; section 11).
3. The office holds the final sanction: excommunication for members, and for priests who obey a court, the threat of defrocking (technique 28; section 15).
4. Leaving costs both church and people, because church, ethnicity and self are fused (techniques 14 and 24).
5. With no other route to the sacraments and no identity outside the church, the member stays, and the sanction keeps its force (section 15).

Techniques that feed it. 3 · Future faking, 5 · Devaluation, 28 · Discard, 24 · Identity erosion.

Why it closes. The office that defines unworthiness is the only one that can lift it, and the sanction it holds costs a member family and people as well as the sacraments. Fear of the sanction keeps members inside, where the sanction applies.

Where it could be broken, and by whom. It weakens where church and ethnic belonging can be separated; in the diaspora, leaving is legally free (section 24). It also weakens where clergy stop treating fasting failure and impurity as unworthiness, which is in the hands of parish priests and bishops. This paragraph is analysis, not a documented finding.

An example from this page. When a court ordered the church in 2010 to license remarriages, the Pope refused and threatened to defrock priests who complied (section 15).

3 · Children



3

Baptism, fasting and Sunday school fuse faith and ethnic identity before choice.

How it runs.

1. Infant baptism confers a lifelong identity before the child can choose (technique 19).
2. Long fasting seasons are practiced from childhood, and purity restrictions begin in childhood (section 11; technique 13).
3. Church schools and Sunday schools are the primary socialization (section 11).
4. Church, ethnicity and self are fused, so leaving later means losing family and people (technique 24; section 15).
5. Those children grow up, baptize their own children and send them to the same Sunday schools.

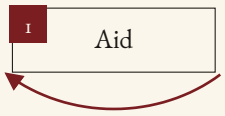
Techniques that feed it. 19 · Manufactured consent, 13 · Normalization, 24 · Identity erosion, 14 · Isolation.

Why it closes. Each generation is enrolled before it can choose and formed before it can compare, and by the time a choice is possible, faith and ethnic identity have become one thing. The loop does not need anyone to decide to continue it; it continues unless someone decides to stop.

Where it could be broken, and by whom. It weakens where children are taught the faith without being taught that leaving it means leaving their people. That choice sits with parents and with Sunday-school teachers; the Eritrean Sunday-school renewal movement shows that Sunday schools can also be a place of dissent (section 11). This paragraph is analysis, not a documented finding.

An example from this page. Mariam, the composite in section 2, has not eaten before the Liturgy since she was a girl, and cannot imagine anyone she could ask to change the rule that traps her friend.

4 · Aid



4

Church welfare in weak states creates debt and loyalty, and state settlements of schisms come with funding [7].

How it runs.

1. The Coptic Church runs welfare and schools where the state provides little (section 4; technique 2).
2. Help that is the only help creates debt, and loyalty to the church follows (technique 2).
3. The patriarch serves as the state's interlocutor for the community, which lets a state manage millions through one office (section 10).
4. When the church splits, the state settles it: the 2023 Ethiopian settlement, brokered by the prime minister, included funding and resources for churches in Oromia (sections 8 and 9).
5. The question this page could not answer follows from it: when the state removes a patriarch, who in the church says no? (section 3).

Techniques that feed it. 2 · Weaponized generosity, 22 · Benevolent control, 26 · Financial control, 30 · Plausible deniability.

Why it closes. The church's standing with its members rests on help the state does not give, and its standing with the state rests on managing those members. Each side supplies what the other needs to keep the arrangement.

Where it could be broken, and by whom. It weakens where the state provides welfare itself, where synods settle their own disputes, and where settlements and their funding are published, as section 12 asks under technique 26. That lies with governments and with the synods. This paragraph is analysis, not a documented finding.

An example from this page. In February 2023 the prime minister brokered the settlement of the Oromia synod schism, in which about 30 people had been killed, and the settlement allocated funding and resources to churches in Oromia (sections 5 and 9).

5 · Labor



5

The church takes labor as well as fees and loyalty; this page records little more about monastic or parish labor than that and the diaspora boards of section 18.

How it runs.

1. Monasteries historically offered refuge and education, and the Coptic Church runs welfare and schools where the state provides little (section 4).
2. The church takes labor as well as fees and loyalty (section 12, stage Extract).
3. Diaspora parish boards raise funds and remit them, and are asked to do so without published accounts (section 18).
4. Monastic superiors are asked to keep internal conflict inside, and monastic and synodal discipline is closed (sections 15 and 18).
5. The work goes on under patriarchs and holy synods, which govern each church (section 7).

Techniques that feed it. 26 · Financial control, 14 · Isolation, 24 · Identity erosion.

Why it closes. The work and the money move up to patriarchates and synods, and the discipline that governs the people doing the work comes back down from them. Only the Armenian Church gives lay delegates a majority in the body that chooses its head (section 4).

Where it could be broken, and by whom. It weakens where diaspora boards publish what they send; section 18 names this as the point where a board could refuse. The Armenian assembly, two-thirds lay, shows another model within this family (sections 4 and 7). This paragraph is analysis, not a documented finding.

An example from this page. Section 18 records diaspora parish boards that raise and send funds, see the accounts, and are asked to remit without published accounts.

6 · Scandal



6

A monastic killing was prosecuted by the state [II]; otherwise, synodal discipline is closed.

How it runs.

1. In 2018 the abbot of St Macarius Monastery, Bishop Epiphanius, was murdered (sections 5 and 19).
2. The state, not the church, prosecuted: a former monk was executed in 2021, and an accomplice's sentence was reduced to life (section 19).
3. Monastic and synodal discipline is otherwise closed (section 15, sacred secrecy).
4. Monastic superiors are asked to keep internal conflict inside (section 18).
5. Complaints about clergy are framed as weak faith (technique 6), and what becomes public is what a state court handles.

Techniques that feed it. 6 · Gaslighting, 27 · Manufactured crisis, 30 · Plausible deniability.

Why it closes. Discipline is exercised by the synod and published by no one, so the only record that reaches members is one a state produces. A complaint about clergy framed as weak faith never reaches that stage.

Where it could be broken, and by whom. It weakens where a synod publishes its disciplinary decisions, and where monastic superiors decline to keep conflict inside (section 18). The first lies with the patriarch and synod of each church. This paragraph is analysis, not a documented finding.

An example from this page. The murder of Bishop Epiphanius in 2018 is the one internal case on this page with a public record, and that record exists because it went to a criminal court (section 19).

7 · Persecution



7

This is the strongest loop on this page. Real martyrdom [9] [10] makes internal criticism unspeakable.

How it runs.

1. Persecution is real: the 2011 Alexandria bombing killed 23, and the 2017 Palm Sunday bombings killed about 45 (section 5).
2. Shared memory of martyrdom binds members to the hierarchy (technique 20).
3. Criticism is framed as helping the persecutors of Christians, and critics are cast as agents of hostile outsiders (section 12, stage Confuse; technique 11).
4. Outside threats are cited to end internal debate (technique 27).
5. Internal questions go unasked, and the next attack renews the memory.

Techniques that feed it. 20 · Trauma bonding, 11 · Projection, 27 · Manufactured crisis, 14 · Isolation.

Why it closes. The more real the threat, the stronger the case for silence. Each attack strengthens the solidarity that protects the hierarchy from its own members' questions.

Where it could be broken, and by whom. It weakens where members separate grief for the martyrs from deference to the office; section 12's counter to technique 20 puts it plainly. Section 3 answers the objection directly: persecution does not make a divorce rule just. The twenty-five Armenian bishops who backed their Catholicos show that solidarity can also check a state (section 4). This paragraph is analysis, not a documented finding.

An example from this page. Section 3 sets out the objection this loop produces, "You are criticizing persecuted Christians", and answers it.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

The loops explain why good people stay in arrangements they would never sign up for from scratch. The more you have already put in, the harder it is to walk away. Researchers call this the sunk-cost effect (Arkes & Blumer, 1985), and it works on time, money and relationships alike. Ask yourself: if you were starting today, knowing what you know, would you join?

14 Say versus do

BEFORE YOU READ

Direct, checkable comparisons: a public statement on one side, the documented record on the other, and the receipt that links them. This is the most falsifiable section on the page, because each row either matches its source or it doesn't.

A third has charged a Catholicos with obstructing enforcement of a court order.

What they say, what the record shows

THEY SAY	THE RECORD SHOWS	RECEIPT
"The church is independent of the state."	Eritrea removed a patriarch [2]; Ethiopia's prime minister brokered a synod deal [7]; Armenia has charged its Catholicos with obstructing enforcement of a court order [13].	GOVERNMENT REPORT · COURT RECORD
"Marriage is protected."	Divorced Copts cannot remarry without church permission, left in place when the highest constitutional court halted a 2010 order against the church [4].	COURT RECORD
"We are one church."	Kerala's property dispute ran for decades; implementation was still stalled in 2024, and in 2026 the state proposed mediation [3] [27].	COURT RECORD

Accountability or theatre?

- **Last ran:** A government removed a patriarch [2]. Another government settled a schism [7]. A third has charged a Catholicos with obstructing enforcement of a court order [13].
- **Chair now:** The patriarchs and holy synods hold it, together with the governments they depend on.

- **Predict:** The next state–church confrontation will be framed by both sides as defending the faith.

Words used here

TERM	INSIDE MEANING	WHAT IT DOES	SAID PLAINLY
"Permission to remarry"	Church approval	It makes a second marriage a clerical gift [4]	"Your family life needs our signature."
"Obedience to the fathers"	Deference to clergy	It ends lay questions	"Don't ask the bishop."
"Unity of the church"	Communion	It is invoked against dissent in splits [7]	"Your complaint divides us."

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Test one row yourself. Pick a "they say" line you have actually heard said in person, then read the receipt. If the record matches the statement, this page is wrong about that row, and you should tell us. If it doesn't, what does it mean that you had never seen the receipt?

15 Cost & cover

BEFORE YOU READ

What leaving actually costs here, in family, work, housing, money and legal status, and how each of those costs is officially denied. Where the cost is low, the page says so plainly.

What leaving costs

- **Egypt: marriage and divorce go through the church.** The Coptic Church permits divorce essentially only for adultery and controls permission to remarry [4]:
- 2010: the Supreme Administrative Court ordered the Pope to license the remarriage of divorced men.
- The Pope refused and threatened to defrock priests who complied.
- The Supreme Constitutional Court then halted the order's enforcement, leaving marital matters with the church; Egypt has no civil marriage outside a religious ceremony [4].
- In 2026 the government sent parliament a unified personal-status law for Christians, with new provisions on divorce and annulment; it had not passed as of September 2026 [26].
- **Eritrea:** Practicing outside state-registered faiths risks detention, and the Orthodox church itself is under state control [2].
- **Minority communities:** where church and ethnic identity coincide, leaving carries high social and family costs.

The Pope refused and threatened to defrock priests who complied.

The ledger of exit

COST	DOCUMENTED?	DETAIL	THE OFFICIAL DENIAL
Divorce and remarriage (Egypt)	Yes [4]	Church permission is required, and adultery is essentially the only ground	"What God has joined together let no man separate." [4]
Unregistered practice (Eritrea)	Yes [2]	Unregistered practice risks detention	(state) "Registered faiths are free."
Family and ethnicity	Very often	In minority communities, leaving means losing an identity	"Nobody is forced."

How the cost is denied

CHANNEL	LEVEL	NOTE
Explicit policy	Low	Divorce rules [4] and church-building law [8] are written.
Informal enforcement	High	Family and community carry identity and fasting norms.
Leadership distance	Medium	Patriarchates cite state pressure; states cite church autonomy [2] [13].
Doctrinal ambiguity	Low	—
Cultural outsourcing	High	Purity rules attributed to "tradition" [14].
Volunteer enforcement	High	—
Sacred secrecy	High	Monastic and synodal discipline is closed [11].
Exit cost denial	Medium	—

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Leaving is rarely a formal act here. The cost comes through family law, family honor and a community that is also an ethnic identity. For Coptic women especially, the page shows that "leaving" a dead marriage can be impossible without leaving the church, and the church can be impossible to leave without losing family. Which of those doors is open to the women in your family?

16 The ledger

BEFORE YOU READ

The balance sheet. It shows who benefits, who pays, and what leverage flows back to the institution in return for what it gives.

Who benefits

- States benefit when they manage minority churches through their patriarchs, and patriarchates benefit when they trade loyalty for protection [2].
- Winning factions in property disputes benefit [3].
- Clerical hierarchies benefit from holding personal-status permissions [4].

Money out, leverage back

- Persecution is real and continuous [9] [10], and it makes internal critique feel like betrayal of martyrs.

- States gain leverage by recognizing, mediating between or prosecuting patriarchs [2][7][13].
- The church controls personal status in Egypt [4].

Who pays

- Coptic spouses in failed marriages pay [4].
- Eritrean believers of every church pay [2].
- Congregations caught in property wars in Kerala pay [3].
- Ethiopian faithful caught between synod politics and ethnic conflict pay [7].
- Women pay, under purity rules [14] and an all-male clergy.
- Communities that others have murdered, bombed or displaced pay [9][10]. This is the page's first fact.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Find yourself in this table. Are you among those who benefit, those who pay, or both? Most readers are both. The question is whether the exchange was ever explained to you in these terms, and whether you would agree to it if it had been.

Winning factions in property disputes benefit.

17 Who gets hurt most

BEFORE YOU READ

Where the weight lands hardest, and what it compounds with: poverty, childhood, gender, a lack of civil alternatives. This is the human stakes stated plainly.

Where the weight lands

The costs in section 15 do not fall evenly. They fall hardest where a person has the least power inside the institution and the fewest places to go outside it: a Coptic woman whose marriage has failed and who has no

civil route out under current law [4], or a believer in Eritrea, where practice outside the registered faiths risks detention [2]. The table names who carries the most, how, and what makes it worse.

WHO	HOW	COMPOUNDS
Women	They bear purity rules [14], divorce rules [4] and an all-male clergy.	State personal-status law compounds it.
Eritrean believers	The state controls their church [2].	The risk of detention compounds it.
Minority congregations	They face persecution [9] [10].	Emigration compounds it.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

The table puts women first: purity rules, divorce rules and an all-male clergy, compounded by personal-status law. Then Eritrean believers under state control, and minority congregations under persecution. Two quite different kinds of harm are recorded here: harm done *to* these churches by states, and harm done *by* church rules to their own members. Does acknowledging the first make it harder to talk about the second?

The table names who carries the most, how, and what makes it worse.

18 The middle tiers

BEFORE YOU READ

The people in the middle: local clergy, teachers, officials and volunteers who apply rules they did not write. The section exists so that an institution is not collapsed into a monolith, and so that people in the middle can see their own position in it.

Most of the institution's work is done below the patriarch and synod, by people who see decisions without making them. Parish priests, the clerical councils that rule on marriage, monastic superiors and diaspora parish boards each carry part of the load, and each stands at one point where the

next decision could be declined. The table sets out what each tier does, what it sees, what it is asked to do and where it could refuse.

ROLE	DOES	SEES	ASKED	COULD REFUSE
Parish priests	Administer the sacraments and give counsel	Failing and abusive marriages	To counsel reconciliation	To send a spouse back to violence
Clerical personal-status councils	Decide divorce and remarriage [4]	The cases	To apply narrow rules	To delay a case for years
Monastic superiors	Keep discipline	Internal conflict [11]	To keep it inside	To keep it inside
Diaspora parish boards	Raise and send funds	The accounts	To remit	To remit without published accounts

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

If you are a local leader, a teacher or a volunteer, this section is about you. It is not an accusation: most of the people who carry out a rule did not write it. But the middle tier is also where a rule is most often quietly softened, or quietly enforced. Which do you do, and what would happen to you if you chose differently?

19 Documented cases

BEFORE YOU READ

Named, dated, sourced incidents: court records, government inquiries, regulators' findings and on-the-record reporting. Read the outcome lines in particular. They show what actually changed, if anything.

1. **Eritrean Patriarch Antonios: removal (2006) and death in custody (9 Feb 2022)** [2]. GOVERNMENT REPORT

2. ***K.S. Varghese v. St. Peter's & Paul's Syrian Orthodox Church*** **(SC India, 3 Jul 2017)** [3]. COURT RECORD

3. **Egyptian Supreme Administrative Court (2010), its order halted by the Supreme Constitutional Court** [4]. COURT RECORD

4. **Murder of Bishop Epiphanius (2018); former monk executed (2021); accomplice's sentence reduced to life** [11]. COURT RECORD

5. **Armenia: archbishop sentenced to two years (Oct 2025), verdict overturned and retrial ordered (Jun 2026)** [12 25]**; trial of the Catholicos and six bishops (2026)** [13]. COURT RECORD

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

These are not hypotheticals. Five documented cases on this page rest on a named record. The most common reaction to documented cases is "that was them, not us." Before settling on that, read the outcome lines. Did anything change in the structure that allowed each case to happen, or did one person leave while the structure stayed?

20 Precedent

BEFORE YOU READ

What has already been broken once, somewhere, and what would count as real change here. It is a benchmark, not a prediction.

It has been broken before

WHAT	WHO	WHEN	COST
Egyptian courts order a remarriage license (later halted) [4]	Litigants	2010	The Supreme Constitutional Court halted its enforcement
Supreme Court resolves Malankara ownership [3]	Litigants	2017	It took decades and brought clashes, and implementation is slow
Church-construction law replaces presidential approval [8]	Egyptian parliament	2016	The law has been criticized as still restrictive [8]
Bishops publicly back the Catholicos against state pressure [13] [30]	Armenian bishops	2025–26	Clergy are being prosecuted

What would change this page

A civil-marriage option in Egypt would change this page, and so would patriarchal selection and discipline free of state capture.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Some rows here record a change that has already happened somewhere; others name what would count as change here. When you are told something "can't change", it is fair to ask: can't, or won't? And who decided?

21 Voices from inside

BEFORE YOU READ

People from inside Oriental Orthodoxy who raised the hard question publicly, often at real cost. They answer the objection that criticism only ever comes from outsiders.

- **Abune Antonios.** Eritrea's patriarch, he was removed in 2006 after refusing, among other things, to excommunicate members of a Sunday-school renewal movement, and he died under house arrest in 2022 [2].

- **The twenty-five Armenian bishops.** They publicly backed their Catholicos against the government in 2025–26 [13] [30].
- **The Coptic men who asked the courts to let them remarry.** The Supreme Administrative Court agreed in 2010; the Pope refused, and the Supreme Constitutional Court halted the order's enforcement [4].
- **The Oromia bishops of 2023.** Their break over language and representation forced the church and the government to the table [7] [17].

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Were these people traitors, or the most loyal members their tradition had? Most were treated as the first at the time, and some are honored as the second now. If someone in your community raised one of these questions tomorrow, how would they be treated, and by you?

The Coptic men who asked the courts to let them remarry.

22 Regional variants

BEFORE YOU READ

The same tradition under different governments. What a member can say, leave, marry or inherit depends heavily on the state, and these cards show how differently it plays out.

Egypt

APEX: The Coptic Pope — Tawadros II, chosen by altar lot in 2012 [6].

LAW: The church controls personal status [4], and the 2016 church-construction law governs church building [8].

DOCUMENTED: The record includes the 2011 Alexandria and 2017 Palm Sunday bombings [9] [10], the 2018 monastery murder [11] and the remarriage cases [4].

EXIT: Leaving the church can mean leaving the only lawful route to marriage and divorce available to you [4].

REGULATOR: The courts regulate, and the Supreme Constitutional Court halted an order against the church [4].

TELL: This is a minority church that needs the state's protection, in a state that leaves the church in charge of Christian marriage.

Ethiopia

APEX: The Patriarch and Holy Synod lead the church.

LAW: The Derg's 1975 land nationalization took the church's land [5].

DOCUMENTED: The record includes the 1979 execution of Patriarch Theophilos [5], the 2023 schism and settlement [7] and the Tigrayan church's separate administration [17].

EXIT: Where church and ethnicity coincide, leaving carries family costs.

REGULATOR: In practice the federal government regulates the church [7].

TELL: The largest Oriental church has had its future decided by the state twice: by the Derg in the 1970s and in the prime minister's office in 2023.

Eritrea

APEX: The patriarch leads the church; since 2025 he has been Abune Basilios [18].

LAW: The state registers the faiths permitted to practice [2].

DOCUMENTED: The record documents Abune Antonios's removal and house arrest [2].

EXIT: Practicing outside the registered faiths risks detention [2].

REGULATOR: No independent regulator exists.

TELL: It is the plainest case in this book of a state choosing a church's head.

Armenia

APEX: The Catholicos of All Armenians leads the church; Karekin II was elected in 1999 [15].

LAW: The state has brought criminal prosecutions against clergy in 2025–26 [12][13].

DOCUMENTED: The record documents the 2026 trial of the Catholicos and six bishops, charged with obstructing enforcement of a court order [13].

EXIT: Leaving is legally free.

REGULATOR: The courts regulate, under a government in open conflict with the church [12].

TELL: Here the pressure runs the other way: a national church with an elected, largely lay assembly, facing a state that wants its leader gone.

India

APEX: Two rival authorities lead the church in Kerala: the Malankara Orthodox Catholicos and the Jacobite faction under the Syriac patriarch [3].

LAW: The 2017 Supreme Court judgment governs who administers the churches [3].

DOCUMENTED: The record documents decades of litigation over about 1,100 churches [3].

EXIT: Leaving is legally free.

REGULATOR: The courts and the state government regulate [3].

TELL: The judgment settled ownership on paper, and the state told the courts in 2024 that it could not enforce it, and in 2026 proposed mediation [3] [27].

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

This page covers Egypt, Ethiopia, Eritrea, Armenia and India. Your country changes what this tradition can do to you, and what you can do about it. If you live somewhere not listed, ask which of these cards your country most resembles. If you are a voter, note that each of these arrangements was chosen by a government.

23 The questions

BEFORE YOU READ

The six questions the documented record could not resolve. Each is set out below: why it is being asked, and a concrete example already on this page that it points back to.

QUESTION 1 OF 6

If a Coptic woman cannot end a failed marriage and remarry in her church, and her state offers no civil marriage under current law [4] (a 2026 draft law with divorce and annulment provisions had not passed as of September 2026 [26]), whose protection is the rule?

WHY THIS IS ASKED

The rule is described as protecting marriage. The question asks whom it protects in practice, when a woman has no religious or civil way out of a marriage that has failed.

EXAMPLE ALREADY ON THIS PAGE

The say-do table sets "Marriage is protected" beside the record: divorced Copts cannot remarry without church permission, and in 2010 Egypt's Supreme Constitutional Court halted an order against that rule [4].

QUESTION 2 OF 6

When a government removes a patriarch [2], what does "autocephaly" mean?

WHY THIS IS ASKED

Autocephaly means self-governance. If a government can remove the head of a self-governing church, the word no longer describes what happens. The question asks readers to check the word against the event.

EXAMPLE ALREADY ON THIS PAGE

The say-do table records that Eritrea removed a patriarch [2]. The reach section adds that the patriarch's refusal to excommunicate members of a Sunday-school renewal movement was among the charges used against him.

QUESTION 3 OF 6

Who owns the church you pray in, and why did it take a Supreme Court to decide [3]?

WHY THIS IS ASKED

Property disputes show where authority really lives. If the answer to "who owns this church?" took decades of litigation, then the people who pray there did not decide it.

EXAMPLE ALREADY ON THIS PAGE

The money section records that the Supreme Court of India gave the Malankara Orthodox faction the right to administer about 1,100 churches in 2017. The say-do table adds that implementation still stalls.

QUESTION 4 OF 6

If women may not enter church for weeks after giving birth to a daughter [14], who decided the body God made is unclean?

WHY THIS IS ASKED

A purity rule that depends on the sex of the newborn is hard to explain as anything other than a judgment on women. The question asks who made it, and on what authority.

EXAMPLE ALREADY ON THIS PAGE

The reach section records the Ethiopian Orthodox practice [14]: after childbirth, women stay away from church for 40 days after a boy and 80 days after a girl. The who-gets-hurt table lists purity rules as the first burden on women.

QUESTION 5 OF 6

What does the diaspora parish send home, and who accounts for it?

WHY THIS IS ASKED

Money that crosses borders is hard to trace from either end. The question asks whether anyone, in either country, can see the whole flow.

EXAMPLE ALREADY ON THIS PAGE

The money section records that diaspora parishes registered as charities in the UK file public accounts and that US churches are generally exempt from public filing, but that financial disclosure is otherwise "generally minimal and jurisdiction-dependent."

QUESTION 6 OF 6

The martyrs refused to bend to rulers. When a prime minister brokers your synod's peace [7] or charges your Catholicos with defying a court order [13], who is bending?

WHY THIS IS ASKED

These churches honor martyrs who refused to bend to rulers. The question applies that standard to the present, where governments broker settlements and prosecute church leaders.

EXAMPLE ALREADY ON THIS PAGE

The say-do table sets "The church is independent of the state" beside three records: Eritrea removed a patriarch [2], Ethiopia's prime minister brokered a synod deal [7], and Armenia has charged its Catholicos with obstructing a court order [13].

In closing

1. Your church outlasted empires by refusing to bend where it mattered. That is the precise standard for a church that bends to a state to keep its patriarch, or bends a woman's life to keep a canon.
2. You can keep every fast and still ask who decides whether your sister may remarry. The oldest churches have always argued. That is what the councils were.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Choose one question and ask it this month, out loud, to a real person who could answer it. Then write down what happened. Were you answered, redirected, or told that asking was the problem? Whichever it was, the response is information.

24 Leaving safely here

BEFORE YOU READ

Practical, non-theological guidance for someone who needs to step back or step away safely. It is a safety document, not an argument.

Practical guidance, not legal advice.

1. **In Egypt,** marriage and divorce for Copts run through the church; take legal advice before you act on either [4].
2. **In Eritrea,** religious practice outside the registered faiths risks detention [2]; if you are abroad, take asylum advice before returning.
3. **In the diaspora,** leaving is legally free; the costs are family and community ones.
4. **If you were abused,** go to the police, not the priest or bishop.
5. **Find support** from the organizations in section 25 [20] [21] [22].

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Even if this section is not for you, it may be for someone you know. Most people who leave a high-demand community say that the first person who listened without trying to argue them back mattered more than anything else. Could that person be you?

25 Where to get help

BEFORE YOU READ

Organizations that can help, each checked directly against its own site, with the date of the check. Nothing here is endorsed beyond that check.

Checked 2026-09-27.

ORGANIZATION (continued)	FOR	WHERE	CONTACT
Faith to Faithless	People leaving high-control religion	UK	**0800 448 0748** (freephone; Monday 10:00–13:00, Wednesday 10:00–13:00, Thursday 16:00–19:00 UK time) [20]
Recovering from Religion	People questioning or leaving faith	US, Canada and online	**(844) 368-2848** [21]
ICSA	Former members of high-control groups; families	International	Via website [22]
NAPAC	Adult survivors of childhood abuse	UK	**0808 801 0331** [23]

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Save one contact now, before anyone needs it: **Faith to Faithless** (people leaving high-control religion; UK). People in crisis rarely have the energy to research options. Having a name ready is one of the most useful things you can do for someone else.



26

Sources

BEFORE YOU READ

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WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

Don't take this page's word for anything either. People tend to believe a claim more the more often they have heard it, whether or not it is true; this is the "illusory truth effect" (Hasher, Goldstein & Toppino, 1977). Spot-check three citations at random. If any fails, tell us, and it will be corrected and logged.

27 What changed on this page

BEFORE YOU READ

A dated log of what changed on this page: corrections, additions and new sources. Changes are logged in public rather than made quietly.

- **2026-10-03:** An Armenian archbishop's two-year sentence is now shown as overturned on appeal in June 2026, and the charge against the Catholicos and six bishops is stated (obstructing enforcement of a court order). Egypt's 2010 court action is described as the sources give it: the Supreme Constitutional Court halted an order against the church. The 2026 draft law that would add divorce and annulment provisions for Egyptian Christians, and Kerala's 2026 mediation proposal, are noted. Four technique grades were corrected, the "Cultural (weak)" grade was replaced, and an Evidence row now sums the grades. Membership, patriarch-election and diaspora-filing statements were corrected, and seven sources were added.
- **2026-09-27:** Added Branches, Law & state, Money in numbers (UK Coptic accounts 2020–2024), Voices from inside, five regional cards, Leaving safely and Where to get help.
- **2026-09-29:** Disclosure scorecard added: rated on the Coptic Orthodox Church's UK body, whose accounts, pay bands and declared safeguarding policy are on the charity register [24]; police-first reporting, a removal procedure and on-the-record replies are not established from any public source for any church in this family.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU

This page keeps a public log of its own changes, mistakes included. Does the institution you belong to, give to, or were raised in keep one like it? If not, how would you know what it got wrong, and when?

Colophon

Set in EB Garamond (SIL Open Font License), regular, italic and bold, with true small capitals and old-style figures in text and lining tabular figures in tables. Laid out with Paged.js in Chromium from the same Markdown that feeds the website. US Letter, single-sided, tagged for accessibility and checked against PDF/UA-1 with veraPDF. Built 2026-10-13. Text checked 2026-10-03.

Palette: ink, oxblood, gold, cream, rule. Seven type sizes. Rules of 0.4 pt and 2 pt only.